“Well, the attack took place right on the nose 7 P.M. our time. About 11 minutes over the target areas. Preliminary report. All planes withdrew but two of our F-Ill’s are unreported. Maybe it’s only radio failure. Maybe they are down. We don’t know as of this time. One thing seems sure. It was a success.”

During the first twenty-four hours, the White House received 126,000 phone calls—15,000 couldn’t get through—in response to the attack, and in the following twenty-four hours, there were 160,000 calls and 16,000 couldn’t get through. They were more than seventy percent favorable.

Tragically, one of our missiles went off track during the attack and caused fatalities in a civilian neighborhood. We had intended to strike military targets only, and I deeply regretted the mishap. I was also deeply saddened that two crewmen were shot down and lost, and that another American may have died as a result of the attack: After the bombing, according to reports that we found credible, Qaddafi sought out the terrorists who had kidnapped Peter Kilburn, librarian at the American University in Beirut, and paid them a fortune to ransom him. Then Kilburn and two British hostages (apparently because of Britain’s cooperation with us during the raid) were murdered in cold blood.

As tragic as the loss of life was, I don’t think they were lives lost in vain: After the attack on Tripoli, we didn’t hear much more from Qaddafi’s terrorists.

The following month, Bud McFarlane, interrupting his brief retirement, made a secret mission to Teheran. The Israeli go-betweens involved in the Iranian initiative told him that he would meet face-to-face with the moderate Iranians who supposedly wanted to establish a dialogue with the United States. Following the meeting, he was told, the four surviving hostages—Associated Press reporter Terry